

Shadow

May 2026

For a while, I ran. Every time my sole smacked the pavement, it left a tiny fracture in my heel. I aimed my head steadily forward as my arms flailed about to keep my footing at this reckless pace. Eventually, I had convinced myself that I wasn't running away from anything in particular. I was merely trying to get to the finish line, wherever I thought that might have been. And yet, even though I thought I believed nothing was chasing me, I had the sense to keep running. It was as if some part of me was unwilling to surrender to the faintest notion of something sinister nipping at my heels. And that part of me was winning.

Still, my curiosity got the best of me, although I never deigned to turn my head and risk being dubbed a paranoid wimp. As I turned sharp corners into half-lit alleyways, I hoped I might catch the tail of a tiger's broad shadow. As I leapt across narrow brooks, I silently listened for the sound of paws splashing behind me. And as I stared down at my narrow-eyed reflection in the mirror before my morning coffee, I thought my assailant might accidentally reveal himself by creaking through the doorway at an inopportune time. Alas, there was no sign that I was being followed, and yet I became more and more certain that I was.

It was Wednesday morning when it hit me. I was stirring my instant coffee at six a.m. during that cold, lonely hour before sunrise, just before the Earth gives up its hope for another day. The day's first wayward shadows began sprouting from trees, birthed by that shiny yolk as it wearily climbed above the hills. I realized that I was right: there was someone following me. And that thing had followed me to Newark. Indeed, it followed me everywhere I went. It was there when I fixed my tie in that gaudy hotel room in Helsinki, while I anxiously rehearsed my research presentation into a foggy mirror. It was there when I slept on the greasy carpeted floor of the St. Louis airport when the weather was too rough to depart, with my mind groggy and my eyes streaked with red. It was there when I came across a photograph, taken less than a year ago, in which I rejoiced with people who meant everything to me at the time, but who I now know I may never speak to again.

It was something inside me. It was the irreconcilable guilt that tore at my sides like a sharp splinter that rudely stings the frontrunner a hundred yards before the end of a neck-and-neck footrace. It was the idealized vision of "elsewhere" that I had construed in my imagination. It was the insatiable itch to abandon the life of comfort and stability I had built, and to start anew upon rocky sandstone pillars. Of course I never heard its footsteps, or saw its reflection, or felt its cold breath – it was my own shadow all along.

Shadows are those dark things we leave behind us, which occasionally enter our view but never block our path, unless we are foolish enough to let them. Still, there is power in their sinister silence; indeed, it is their intangibility and irrevocability that makes them so fearsome. But shadows are poor, misunderstood things; mere projections of ourselves on our surroundings, condemned to a lower dimension. Only by facing your shadow can you truly know it. See how it curves, how it phases, how it meshes into its medium. I knew this at once. And so I turned around. And I saw a familiar face – the face of a friend, really.

What was I so afraid of?